



ARRI interview with Deakins

Roger Deakins gives his feedback on the ALEXA Mini LF, Signature Prime lenses, and the TRINITY stabilizer. <https://digit.in/may20-37>



Lee Smith on the 'one-shot' feel

The editor of 1917, Lee Smith, talks about how the shooting style affected the editing. <https://digit.in/may20-38>

The Alexa Mini LF provided the best overall image quality in theatre format in compact size when studying the picture. It also had a lower noise with higher usable sensitivity. The camera gave Deakins the freedom to move the camera whichever way he wanted. He also loved the LF format because shooting a close-up on a 40mm lens did not have the distortion of a 32mm or 35mm lens, but it had a field-of-view similar to that of a 32mm or 35 mm lens. The camera being small and lightweight made it easy to attach onto drones for overhead scenes while not losing stability or just slowing down the drone itself.

LENSES

The lenses used in this film were the Signature Prime lenses. In an interview with ARRI, Deakins said that he prefers lenses that show the world the way it actually looks. The Signature Prime lenses are a good choice for someone working with natural light sources while avoiding lens flares as much as possible. To top that off, these lenses are pretty lightweight, which was extremely helpful for shooting this film. 99 percent of the film was shot on a 40mm lens while some scenes such as the tunnel scenes were shot on a 35mm lens to give a tunnel feel. The river scenes were sometimes shot on a 47mm lens to kind of distort and lose the background.

STABILIZERS

With this movie, Deakins decided to go with the TRINITY stabilizers. Deakins mentioned that the idea of the film was to have a remorseless solid frame going across the landscape. He also mentioned that the TRINITY stabilizers were more lock solid and stable than a Steadicam. According to Charlie Rizek, the TRINITY Operator in 1917, the TRINITY provided the fluidity of a traditional steadicam combined with the precision of a remote head giving the operator the freedom to explore the entire space around.

LIGHTING

The primary light source for this film was natural light. This included scenes

shot in the trenches and bunkers too. Since the camera had to be moved 360 degrees following the characters, any artificial lighting would have shown up on camera. Deakins preferred cloudy days to sunny days since sunny weather would translate to more shadows. The lighting had to be consistent since the story was taking place in real-time.

Artificial lighting was used for night scenes. The flares were tied by wires and pulled up, and were supposed to last a certain time frame and brightness. This resulted in a noir-ish look. With complete control over the lighting, for the night scene, Deakins built a 360-degree burning church lit by 2000 1K bulbs set on dimmers. The CGI fire was added in post-production.

EDITING

Academy award-winning editor, Lee Smith was in charge of cutting and piecing together this work of art. In an interview with Hey U Guys, Lee Smith revealed that the assembly of the film was taking place as it was being shot and then being presented to Mendes each day with rough sound effects and music. Using the blocking aspect as transition to stitch in a new scene was something new for him.

THE LIGHTHOUSE

Director: Robert Eggers

Cinematographer: Jarin Blaschke

Directed by Robert Eggers, The Lighthouse, starring Willem Dafoe and Robert Pattinson is a psychological horror story set in the 1890s about two lighthouse keepers on a mysterious remote island. The film focuses on the gradual descent into madness due to confinement during the harsh stormy weather, also known as cabin fever. What garnered attention mainly was the look and feel of the film. It was unique. The film looked vintage. Black and white with a boxy aspect ratio. To top that off the brilliantly executed method acting by the two individuals and the hauntingly beautiful music.

The making of this movie was not as easy as just filming it, editing a gray-scale filter on and changing the aspect

ratio to make it look vintage. It had to look and feel genuine. Robert Eggers was fixated on how the film should look. He decided that the film would be shot on a 35mm negative film, black and white format, a 1.19:1 aspect ratio and a mono audio mix. The Lighthouse was shot on the Panavision Panaflex Millennium XL2 on a KODAK Double-X 5222 Filmstock. It has an aggressive grain structure and contrast.

Jarin Blaschke is the cinematographer for this movie and is best known for his work in the previous Robert Eggers movie, The VVitch. In an interview with Musicbed, Blaschke revealed that originally the movie was going to be shot in 1.33:1, which was the standard academy ratio. However, since it was a two-hander movie with a dark and ominous atmosphere, in a confined space, Blaschke suggested that the confinement would be expressed in a way better way, if the movie was shot in a 1.19:1 aspect ratio.

ORTHOCHROMATIC LOOK AND THE CUSTOM FILTER

Achieving an orthochromatic (sensitive to all visible light except red) look in the film was difficult. In the interview with Musicbed, Blaschke revealed that he wanted to prevent the red light from coming into the camera. After switching through multiple blue and blue-green filters to no avail, Panavision came to Blaschke's rescue. Mike Carter from Panavision introduced Blaschke to Rob Engvaldsen at Schneider Optics, who offered to make a custom filter for the crew. Blaschke had to draw and send a spectrograph indicating what colour wavelengths he did not want. The team received the custom filter within a month's time. All costs were handled by Panavision.

Going through this procedure brought out more texture. Slight changes and fluctuations in light or facial expressions would be pronounced. Skin texture, pores, blemishes and blood vessels are very noticeable. This made the weathered, beaten-down look of the lighthouse keepers more prominent.